

# **A Quarto book project with Tufte-style layout**

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# Overview

This is a simple book project allowing you to write straightforward Markdown and achieve a layout loosely inspired by Edward Tufte and more specifically by Rachel Cockerell’s book *Melting Point*. It uses Quarto to render output to both responsive HTML and PDF via Latex. The layout supports side-notes in the margins, but keeps traditional footnotes at the bottom of the page, and figure captions beneath the figures they label. Bibliographic references are resolved using the Bibtex data in a defined local file.

Simultaneously generate an HTML website and a PDF of the project with the standard quarto commands `quarto render` or `quarto render --to all`.

The following figure is a screen grab illustrating Rachel Cockerell’s page layout.

The [next page](#) demonstrates how to make your Markdown text work with this design.

[Download and see documentation for Quarto](#), “an open-source scientific and technical publication system.”

Find out more about *Melting Point* on [Rachel Cockerell’s professional website](#).

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| In appearance, Herzl is not only handsome, but royal – tall, broad-shouldered, with finely shaped head and features.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Ray Frank,<br><i>American Hebrew</i> ,<br>1898 |
| Those who see him for the first time are at once both attracted and repelled. He has the face and bearing of a king, with a reserve which at first keeps the stranger at a distance, but he quickly fascinates by the dignity of his bearing and by the classic beauty of his face and figure.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | William Durban,<br><i>Pall Mall Gazette</i>    |
| An artist might paint him, and without the slightest idealization, make an ideal picture. Tall, handsome, black-bearded, clear-eyed, erect in bearing, suave in manner, he looks like kings ought to look.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Cyrus L. Sulzberger                            |
| He was graceful in every movement. Without posing, he assumed a royal air, and even those to whom nothing of him was a mystery, could never rid themselves of a certain awe and reverence which his presence compelled. His individuality was striking, and he was fully conscious of it; he liked to be surrounded by friends. In society he would flash a hundred phrases of polished thought. He had a wonderful capacity for detail, and would throw an odd phrase back at one, years after its utterance.                                                                                       | Jacob de Haas                                  |
| I still remember the first time I saw you. You were making a speech, and being ‘sharp’ – so sharp! You were smiling ironically. And I began to envy you. If only I could speak and smile in that way, I thought to myself. I remember a meeting with you at some ball or other one night. I was in a particularly happy mood that evening and, as I thought, inexpressibly elegant. Then you appeared. With a steady haughty glance you examined my tie and crushed me. It was clear that I must learn how to make up my ties better, or at least to do something distinguished in some other field. | Arthur Schnitzler to<br>Theodor Herzl          |

Figure 1: Sample page from *Melting Point*.

# 1 How to use this template project

Write your Markdown as you would in any other Quarto project. Text in the main body looks like this paragraph. In both HTML and PDF output, it spans the standard content width, leaving space on the exterior side of the page for marginal notes .

All of Quarto's normal features for technical writing , such as footnotes and indexed labelled figures, are available .

See Quarto  
documentation on  
[supported Markdown](#).

## 1.1 Footnotes

To place a footnote in your text, create an identifier using squarebrackets with a caret; start a line with the same identifier and a colon to write the content of the footnote. This markup:

```
Main body content.[^fn]

[^fn]: Footnote content.
```

produces this output:

Main body content.<sup>1</sup>

In the HTML rendering, hovering over the footnote marker shows its contents in a floating box. In both HTML and PDF renderings, the footnote is placed at the bottom of the page.

## 1.2 Labelled figures

To create a styled labelled figure, use normal Markdown for an embedded image, and add an identifier starting with `#fig-` in curly brackets. The image will span the main text width, with a styled caption placed directly beneath the image.

For example, this Markdown produces this output:

```
![Opening of letter of Ebenezer White to Nelson White.]
(https://neelsmith.quarto.pub/personal/posts/imgs/filled-w-grief.png){#fig-ebenezer}
```

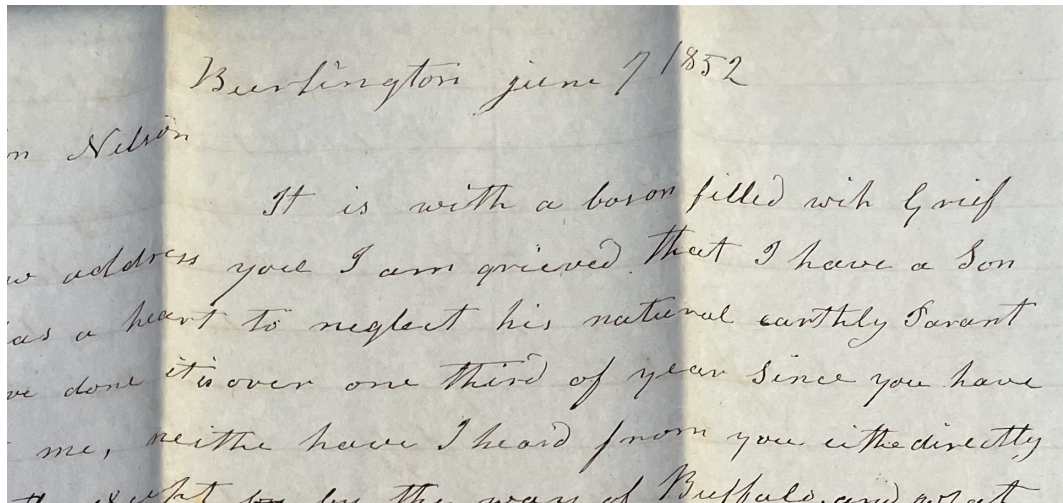


Figure 1.1: Opening of letter of Ebenezer White to Nelson White.

Elsewhere in your text, you can cite the image by replacing # in the identifier with @ to embed a properly labelled link. In this example, embedding the citation @fig-ebenezer produces this labelled link: Figure 1.1. In the HTML version, hovering over the link displays a small image of the figure in a floating panel.

## 1.3 Citing sources

Follow standard Quarto practices to cite sources using reference IDs in a BibTeX bibliography. For example, if the reference ID for your source is @tufte2001, you can include a citation like [tufte2001] to produce this citation in your text: (Tufte 2001). In both HTML and PDF output, citations are linked to full bibliographic information in the [appended bibliography](#).

The bibliographic source file is configured in \_quarto.yml (with the line bibliography: references.bib).

See [Quarto documentation on citations](#).

**Tip:** if you manage your bibliography with Zotero, you can use the BetterBibTex plugin to automatically update an export of your bibliography to whatever file you configure in \_quarto.yml.

## 1.4 Adding marginal notes

This project's configuration defines a column-margin class that lets you add marginal notes. Place the note in square brackets followed by {.column-margin}. To align the note horizontally with a specific passage of the main body text, embed the note in the text at the point you want it to align with. For example, this markup:

```
A paragraph [The content of your marginal note.]{.column-margin}
```

with an aligned marginal note. The paragraph text continues to flow normally in the main text block.

---

<sup>1</sup>Footnote content.

produces this:

A **paragraph** with an aligned marginal note. The paragraph text continues to flow normally in the main text block.

The content of your  
**marginal note.**

## 1.5 Version information and project metadata

The configuration in `_quarto.yml` defines variables for version and date, and uses them in a footer for HTML pages. The same variables are used in the file `releases.qmd` to display the current version and date at the top of a history of releases.

The [following section](#) documents the technical configuration of HTML and PDF rendering in `_quarto.yml`.

## 2 Configuration of visual appearance of HTML and PDF output

### 2.1 HTML formatting

HTML output is styled with Quarto's `cosmo` theme. The included file `custom.css` adds settings for the appearance of text in the project's custom `column-margin` class.

See Quarto documentation on [HTML themes](#).

### 2.2 PDF formatting

PDFs are rendered with the `lualatex` engine. The YAML `geometry` property defines borders and spacing of the main content areas in centimeters.

See Quarto documentation on [PDF configuration](#).

With the `include-in-header` property, the configuration injects some LaTeX into the output pipeline. This code sets up the LaTeX `hyperref` package to create live links from citations in the PDF file, and defines a fallback chain for fonts. The main font is set to Georgia, falling back to Apple Color Emoji for missing characters.

## Bibliographic information for cited sources

Tufte, Edward R. 2001. *The Visual Display of Quantitative Information*. Graphics Press.

# Released versions

Current version: **1.0.0, July 13, 2026.**

## Version history

- **1.0.0:** July 13, 2026. Initial release with the project-specific `column-margin` class for layout of marginal notes. Documentation includes examples illustrating marginal notes, as well as support for the standard Quarto features for footnotes, labelled figures, and bibliographic citations. Brief documentation explains the configuration of the font chain used in producing PDFs.